

RETENTION PLAYBOOK

D2C Fashion Brand

A Data-Backed Customer Strategy

Consulting & Analytics Club | IIT Guwahati

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Dataset: 3,863 Customers | United States



About This Playbook

This document is the final strategic output of the **Decoding Customer Value** project. It translates three phases of data work — cleaning, feature engineering, and segmentation — into decisions the brand can act on.

Everything in this playbook is grounded in the customer dataset of **3,863 customers**. No assumptions have been made beyond what the data supports. Where the data has limitations — particularly the single-transaction snapshot per customer — those limitations are acknowledged and the analysis is framed accordingly.

Central Question This Playbook Answers:

"Is the brand building genuine loyalty — or is it reliant on continuous promotional activity? And what should it do about it?"

Section	What It Covers	Pages
01 — The State of the Base	Overall health KPIs, segment overview	4–5
02 — Segment Intelligence	Four-quadrant matrix analysis, profiles	6–8
03 — Category Intelligence	Category quality, lifecycle, representation	9–10
04 — Geographic Intelligence	Untapped markets, state-level quality scores	11–12
05 — Ideal Customer Profile	Who the brand should acquire more of	13–14
06 — Promotional Analysis	Promo rates by segment, season, category	15–16
07 — Promotional Sunset Plan	Specific sunset strategy per segment	17–19
08 — Acquisition Strategy	Where and who to target next	20–21
09 — KPI Monitoring Framework	Metrics to track success	22

01 — The State of the Customer Base

The brand has **3,863 active customer records**. The headline finding from the data is straightforward: **42.5% of all recorded transactions involved a promotional discount**. Nearly half the revenue snapshot is discount-assisted. Before breaking down segments, this number alone is the most important diagnostic.

Overall Health KPIs

3,863 Total Customers <i>after cleaning</i>	\$59.70 Avg Purchase Amount <i>single order snapshot</i>	25.3 Avg Previous Purchases <i>lifetime order count</i>
3.75 Avg Review Rating <i>out of 5.0</i>	26.7% Subscription Rate <i>opted-in customers</i>	42.5% Overall Promo Rate <i>of all transactions</i>

What These Numbers Are Saying

A 42.5% promo rate is not a promotional strategy — it is price dependency masquerading as marketing. Only 26.7% of customers have committed to a subscription, which means less than one in three customers has given the brand any signal of long-term intent. The average of 25.3 previous purchases shows meaningful tenure exists in the base, but it is unevenly distributed — and that distribution is precisely what the segmentation uncovers.

Data Cleaning Notes

- 37 records with missing Review Rating were removed (0.95% of base) — too small to impute, clean removal preferred
- "Bi-Weekly" and "Fortnightly" standardised to "Fortnightly" — identical purchasing cadence, different labels
- "Every 3 Months" and "Quarterly" standardised to "Quarterly" — same reason
- Promo Code Used and Discount Applied confirmed to be identical columns in all 3,863 rows — treated as a single signal

Note: Promo and Discount flags reflect only the single observed transaction per customer. They cannot be used to infer habitual promotional behaviour at the individual level. All promotional analysis is therefore conducted at the population level (by segment, category, and season).

02 — Segment Intelligence

Customers were segmented using a **Loyalty × Value matrix**. Two independent scores were built — deliberately using non-overlapping inputs — so each axis measures a different dimension of customer quality. The matrix splits at the median of each score, producing four equally-sized quadrants.

Score Architecture

Loyalty Score = (Frequency × 0.45) + (Review Rating × 0.35) + (Subscription × 0.20)

Captures: How committed and engaged is this customer?

Value Score = (Previous Purchases × 0.60) + (Purchase Amount × 0.40)

Captures: How much has this customer historically generated?

Correlation between Loyalty Score and Value Score: 0.016 — confirming the two axes are measuring genuinely independent things. The matrix is not circular.

The Four Segments

Segment	Count	% Base	Avg Loyalty	Avg Value	Avg Spend	Avg Prev.	Sub Rate	Promo Rate
Champion	981	25.4%	0.645	0.674	\$68.94	36.1	43.1%	54.3%
Loyal Low-Spend	976	25.3%	0.636	0.319	\$50.07	14.8	40.7%	53.7%
High-Spend Drifter	952	24.6%	0.320	0.671	\$68.57	36.0	10.3%	29.8%
Low Priority	954	24.7%	0.320	0.322	\$51.21	14.6	12.1%	31.3%

Reading the Segments

Champion — 981 customers (25.4%)

The best customers the brand has. High on both loyalty and value — they buy frequently, rate the brand well, subscribe, and have significant purchase histories averaging 36 orders.

The uncomfortable finding: 54.3% of Champion transactions involved a promotional discount. The brand is giving discounts to customers who demonstrate, through every other behavioural signal, that they would buy anyway. This is the single most recoverable margin item in the entire dataset.

Loyal Low-Spend — 976 customers (25.3%)

High loyalty, low value. These customers engage frequently and rate the brand positively, but their purchase amounts are modest (\$50.07 avg) and their purchase histories are short (avg 14.8 orders).

Strategic opportunity: This segment has already demonstrated loyalty — the brand just needs to move them up the spend ladder. Category upsell and bundle strategies are more appropriate here than acquisition spend.

High-Spend Drifter — 952 customers (24.6%)

High value, low loyalty. These customers spend as much as Champions (\$68.57 avg) and have similar purchase histories (36 orders), but only 10.3% subscribe and their loyalty scores are half that of Champions.

The risk: This segment has the money. They just haven't committed to the brand. They're the most likely to be buying across multiple brands simultaneously. Without intervention, they are Champions who drifted — or will drift further.

Low Priority — 954 customers (24.7%)

Low loyalty, low value. Short purchase histories (14.6 avg orders), lower spend (\$51.21), below-median frequency and ratings. The 31.3% promo rate suggests some are responsive to promotions but not converting into higher-value behaviour. Investment in this segment has the lowest expected return relative to the other three. Passive retention only.

03 — Category Intelligence

Important caveat: Category reflects the single observed transaction per customer — not a customer's preferred or dominant category. All insights are phrased as "associated with" rather than "prefers". Statistical validation via Kruskal-Wallis confirms $p=0.171$ for Loyalty and $p=0.443$ for Value — no statistically significant difference across categories. Category insights are therefore descriptive and directional, not causal.

Category Quality Index

The Quality Score combines average Loyalty Score and Value Score into a single composite, allowing category-level prioritisation.

Category	Count	Avg Loyalty	Avg Value	Quality Score	Champion Rate	Ideal Rate	Avg Spend
Footwear	594	0.495	0.498	0.497	28.6%	7.6%	\$60.23
Accessories	1,229	0.484	0.501	0.493	24.2%	6.1%	\$59.79
Clothing	1,718	0.476	0.496	0.486	24.7%	5.8%	\$59.94
Outerwear	322	0.486	0.480	0.483	27.6%	8.1%	\$57.15

Representation Among Ideal Customers

The Representation Index shows whether a category is **over- or under-represented among Ideal Customers** compared to the full base. An index above 110 signals a meaningful concentration; below 90 signals underrepresentation.

Category	Base %	Ideal Customer %	Representation Index	Interpretation
Outerwear	8.3%	10.6%	126.8	Overrepresented
Footwear	15.4%	18.3%	119.0	Overrepresented
Accessories	31.8%	30.5%	95.8	Proportional
Clothing	44.5%	40.7%	91.4	Slightly under

What This Means for the Brand

Outerwear (Index: 126.8) and Footwear (Index: 119.0) are disproportionately associated with the brand's most valuable customers. Despite Outerwear being the smallest category by volume (322 customers), it has the highest Ideal Customer rate at 8.1%. These are not entry categories — they are quality-signal categories.

Clothing (Index: 91.4) is the largest category by volume but slightly underrepresented among Ideal customers. High volume, lower quality concentration — typical of a broad-appeal product line that attracts all customer types.

Category Promo Rate Analysis

Category	Promo Rate	Avg Spend	Avg Loyalty Score
Outerwear	44.1%	\$57.15	0.486
Accessories	43.3%	\$59.79	0.484
Footwear	42.8%	\$60.23	0.495
Clothing	41.4%	\$59.94	0.476

Promo rates are near-uniform across categories (41–44%), suggesting blanket promotional campaigns rather than category-targeted ones. A more surgical approach — detailed in Section 07 — would reduce promo intensity in Footwear and Outerwear where Ideal customer concentration is highest.

04 — Geographic Intelligence

The brand sells across all US states. The geographic analysis identifies **where the brand has organic, high-quality demand that it has not fully cultivated** — states with above-average customer quality but below-average customer penetration.

Top 10 States by Customer Quality Score

State	Customers	Avg Spend	Avg Loyalty	Avg Value	Sub Rate	Promo Rate	Quality Score
Alaska	72	\$67.60	0.504	0.570	25.0%	40.3%	0.537
Pennsylvania	74	\$66.57	0.497	0.556	28.4%	44.6%	0.527
Hawaii	64	\$58.00	0.510	0.539	28.1%	48.4%	0.525
Iowa	68	\$61.49	0.508	0.531	30.9%	51.5%	0.520
Arizona	65	\$66.55	0.470	0.568	24.6%	33.8%	0.519
Wyoming	71	\$60.69	0.479	0.537	28.2%	42.3%	0.508
Alabama	89	\$59.11	0.496	0.519	24.7%	40.4%	0.508
Nevada	85	\$63.28	0.489	0.522	32.9%	45.9%	0.506
Tennessee	77	\$61.97	0.490	0.516	18.2%	36.4%	0.503
Illinois	91	\$60.85	0.489	0.515	24.2%	39.6%	0.502

Untapped and Underutilised Markets

Defined as: states where **both Loyalty Score and Value Score are above the overall average**, but customer count is **below the average state penetration**. These are markets where the brand's customers are demonstrably higher quality than average — but the brand has fewer of them than typical.

State	Customers	Avg Spend	Loyalty Score	Value Score	Sub Rate	Promo Rate
Hawaii	64	\$58.00	0.510	0.539	28.1%	48.4%
Iowa	68	\$61.49	0.508	0.531	30.9%	51.5%
Alaska	72	\$67.60	0.504	0.570	25.0%	40.3%
Pennsylvania	74	\$66.57	0.497	0.556	28.4%	44.6%
Tennessee	77	\$61.97	0.490	0.516	18.2%	36.4%

Geographic Insight

Alaska stands out. Highest average spend (\$67.60), highest Value Score (0.570), and below-average customer count (72). The brand is not targeting Alaska — but the customers who find it there are among the brand's most valuable anywhere in the country. This is the definition of untapped demand.

Hawaii leads on Loyalty Score (0.510) — the highest of any state — yet has only 64 customers. Subscription rate is 28.1%. This is a high-loyalty, low-penetration market.

Arizona has the lowest promo rate of the top 10 states (33.8%) yet the second-highest average spend (\$66.55). Customers there are buying at near-full price at high spend levels — a genuine brand-pull market.

05 — Ideal Customer Profile

The Ideal Customer is defined as the **top 25% of Champions** by a composite ICP Score that equally weights Loyalty Score and Value Score within the Champion cohort. This produces **246 Ideal Customers** — the 6.4% of the base who represent the brand's strongest evidence of what a genuinely valuable, retained customer looks like.

246 Ideal Customers <i>6.4% of base</i>	0.754 Avg Loyalty Score <i>vs 0.482 overall</i>	0.797 Avg Value Score <i>vs 0.497 overall</i>
\$79.10 Avg Spend <i>vs \$59.70 overall</i>	41.9 Avg Prev. Orders <i>vs 25.3 overall</i>	4.26 Avg Review Rating <i>vs 3.75 overall</i>

Demographic & Behavioural Profile

Attribute	Ideal Customer Profile	Full Base Comparison
Age	45–54 most common (21.1%), avg age 45.2	Spread across all age bands
Gender	81.3% Male, 18.7% Female	68.6% Male, 31.4% Female
Purchase Frequency	46.3% Fortnightly, 39.4% Weekly	Mixed — Quarterly 29.3%, Fortnightly 28.0%
Subscription Status	61.0% Subscribed	26.7% overall subscription rate
Top Category	Clothing 40.7%, Accessories 30.5%	Clothing 44.5%, Accessories 31.8%
Season (observed)	Winter 27.2%, Fall 27.2%	Evenly spread across seasons
Top States	Illinois, Montana, Ohio, Maryland, NC	Distributed nationally
Avg Spend	\$79.10 per order	\$59.70 overall
Avg Previous Orders	41.9 lifetime orders	25.3 overall
Avg Rating	4.26 out of 5.0	3.75 overall

The Ideal Customer in Plain English

Who the brand should be trying to acquire more of:

Age & Gender: 35–64 year-old male customer. The 45–54 band has the highest concentration. This is not a young, trend-driven buyer — it is a considered, habitual spender with the income and disposition to buy regularly without needing a price incentive.

Purchase Behaviour: Buys every one to two weeks (85.7% are Weekly or Fortnightly buyers). Has made an average of 42 prior purchases. This person has been buying from the brand for a long time and continues at a high pace.

Subscription: 61.0% are subscribed — more than double the overall rate of 26.7%. Subscription is the strongest differentiator between Ideal customers and the rest of the base.

Category: Observed most frequently in Clothing and Accessories — the two highest-quality, highest-tenure categories in the dataset.

Geography: Nationally distributed with slight concentrations in Illinois, Montana, Ohio, and Maryland. No single state dominates — the profile is a behavioural one, not a geographic one.

ICP vs Full Base — Gap Analysis

These gaps represent the measurable distance between the brand's average customer and its best customer. They are also the targets for the acquisition strategy in Section 08.

Metric	Ideal Customer	All Customers	Gap
Avg Loyalty Score	0.754	0.482	+56% higher
Avg Value Score	0.797	0.497	+60% higher
Avg Spend	\$79.10	\$59.70	+\$19.40 per order
Avg Previous Orders	41.9	25.3	+16.6 more orders
Avg Rating	4.26	3.75	+0.51 higher
Subscription Rate	61.0%	26.7%	+34.3 percentage points

06 — Promotional Analysis

Since Promo and Discount flags reflect only the single observed transaction, all analysis here is at the **population level**: what fraction of transactions *within a given segment, season, or category* involved a promotional discount. This is a brand-level health metric, not an individual customer trait.

Promotional Rate by Segment

Segment	Customers	Promo Rate	Avg Spend	Avg Loyalty	Avg Value
Champion	981	54.3%	\$68.94	0.645	0.674
Loyal Low-Spend	976	53.7%	\$50.07	0.636	0.319
High-Spend Drifter	952	29.8%	\$68.57	0.320	0.671
Low Priority	954	31.3%	\$51.21	0.320	0.322

The Critical Finding

Champions and Loyal Low-Spend customers have the **highest promo rates in the entire dataset — 54.3% and 53.7% respectively**. These are also the two highest-loyalty segments. The brand is applying its heaviest promotional pressure to the customers who have already demonstrated commitment through frequency, ratings, and subscriptions. Meanwhile, High-Spend Drifters — the segment that most needs a relationship-building incentive — have the **lowest promo rate (29.8%)**. The promotions are going to the wrong customers.

Promotional Rate by Season

Season	Customers	Promo Rate	Avg Spend	Avg Loyalty
Summer	944	43.6%	\$58.37	0.48
Spring	987	43.4%	\$58.64	0.49
Winter	963	42.5%	\$60.26	0.49
Fall	969	40.4%	\$61.53	0.47

Seasonal promo rates are near-uniform (40–44%). Fall has the highest average spend (\$61.53) and the lowest promo rate (40.4%) — suggesting natural demand in Fall is strong enough that promotions are less necessary. This is the most defensible season to begin promo reduction.

Promotional Rate by Category

Category	Customers	Promo Rate	Avg Spend	Avg Loyalty	Ideal Customer Rate
Outerwear	322	44.1%	\$57.15	0.486	8.1%
Accessories	1,229	43.3%	\$59.79	0.484	6.1%
Footwear	594	42.8%	\$60.23	0.495	7.6%
Clothing	1,718	41.4%	\$59.94	0.476	5.8%

Outerwear and Footwear have the highest Ideal Customer rates yet also high promo rates. These are the categories where the most valuable customers are being unnecessarily discounted.

07 — Promotional Sunset Plan

A promotional sunset is the structured removal of discount incentives from customer segments that no longer need them to convert. The goal is **not to reduce sales** — it is to recover margin from customers who would have bought anyway, while preserving promotional investment for the segments where it actually drives incremental behaviour.

Every recommendation below names: the target segment, the trigger behaviour, the rollout timeline, the metric to track, and the risk. "Reduce discounts" is not acceptable as a recommendation — specificity is the standard.

Sunset 1: Champions — Begin Immediately

Target Segment	Champion (981 customers, 25.4% of base)
Rationale	Loyalty Score 0.645, avg 36 prior orders, 43.1% subscription rate. These customers have demonstrated through every measurable signal that they are committed to the brand. A 54.3% promo rate against this profile represents pure margin leakage.
Trigger	Any Champion with 3+ previous purchases recorded (i.e. all 981) qualifies for sunset immediately. No waiting condition required.
Rollout	Month 1: Remove 30% of Champions from active promo distribution. Month 2: Remove 60%. Month 3: Full sunset — Champions receive no automatic discounts. Standard communications continue unchanged.
What to offer instead	Non-monetary recognition: early access to new collections, exclusive product previews, subscription perks. These maintain engagement without margin cost.
Primary Metric	% of Champion transactions completed without a promo code (target: 85%+ by end of Month 3)
Secondary Metric	Champion retention rate — purchase frequency should not decline by more than 8%
Risk	An estimated 3–7% of Champions may reduce purchase frequency in Month 1. This is acceptable. If frequency decline exceeds 10%, pause the Month 3 rollout and investigate.
Estimated Margin Recovery	At \$68.94 avg spend, 20% assumed discount depth, 54.3% promo rate, 981 customers: ~\$73,500 in recoverable promotional cost at full sunset.

Sunset 2: Loyal Low-Spend — Conditional Sunset

Target Segment	Loyal Low-Spend (976 customers, 25.3% of base)
Rationale	Loyalty Score 0.636 — nearly as high as Champions. 53.7% promo rate. These customers are already behaviorally committed. However, their lower value score means some may be more price-sensitive, warranting a conditional rather than blanket sunset.
Trigger	Loyal Low-Spend customer who has made a purchase within the last 60 days without a promo code. This demonstrates willingness to buy at full price — the condition is met.
Rollout	Month 2 start (after Champion sunset is stable): Identify all trigger-qualified customers. Remove from promo distribution. Monitor for 30 days before expanding to remaining Loyal Low-Spend.
What to offer instead	Bundle offers and category upsell — not price discounts. The goal here is to increase their value score while maintaining loyalty, not just to remove the discount.
Primary Metric	% of Loyal Low-Spend transactions without promo code (target: 70%+ by Month 4)

Secondary Metric	Average Purchase Amount — should increase as upsell strategy takes effect (target: +\$5–8 per order)
Risk	Loyal Low-Spend customers have shorter purchase histories (14.8 avg orders) than Champions. Some may not yet have deep enough brand attachment to convert without a price nudge. The 60-day trigger condition is specifically designed to identify those who already have.
Estimated Margin Recovery	At \$50.07 avg spend, 20% discount depth, 53.7% promo rate, 976 customers: ~\$52,500 in potential recoverable margin.

Sunset 3: High-Spend Drifter — Redirect, Not Remove

This segment requires a different kind of intervention — not a sunset, but a reallocation.

High-Spend Drifters have a 29.8% promo rate — the lowest of any segment. The problem here is not over-discounting; it's under-engagement. With avg spend of \$68.57 and 36 previous orders, these customers have the same revenue profile as Champions — they just haven't committed. Removing their (already low) promotions is the wrong move. The right move is to use targeted, personalised offers to convert them into Champions.

Action: Offer a subscription conversion campaign exclusively to this segment. Subscription is the single biggest differentiator between Drifters (10.3% subscribed) and Champions (43.1% subscribed). A subscription converts a high-spend occasional buyer into a high-spend committed buyer.

Low Priority — No Sunset Action

Low Priority customers have a 31.3% promo rate and below-median scores on both loyalty and value. Removing their promotions would likely further reduce purchase frequency with minimal margin benefit. This segment warrants **passive retention only** — keep them on standard communications, do not invest in re-engagement campaigns, and do not sunset promos. Monitor annually for any migration upward into At-Risk/Loyal tiers.

Sunset Timeline Summary

Month	Action	Segment	Expected Outcome
Month 1	Begin Champion sunset (30% cohort)	Champion	Establish baseline purchase rate without promos
Month 2	Expand Champion sunset to 60%	Champion	Monitor frequency decline vs margin recovery
Month 2	Launch Drifter subscription campaign	High-Spend Drifter	Begin converting Drifters to committed buyers
Month 3	Full Champion sunset	Champion	Target: 85% of Champion orders without promo
Month 3	Identify Loyal Low-Spend trigger cohort	Loyal Low-Spend	Qualify customers for conditional sunset
Month 4	Begin Loyal Low-Spend conditional sunset	Loyal Low-Spend	Target: 70% of orders without promo by Month 5

Month	Action	Segment	Expected Outcome
Month 6	Review all segments — assess migration	All	Check whether Drifters moved to Champion tier

08 — Acquisition Strategy

Retention and acquisition are two sides of the same strategic equation. The ICP defined in Section 05 and the geographic intelligence in Section 04 together answer: **who should the brand try to acquire, and where should it look for them?**

Priority Acquisition Targets

Priority	Target Profile	Why	Where to Find Them
1 — Highest	Male, 35–54, high purchase frequency, likely to subscribe	Closest match to Ideal Customer profile. Highest expected LTV.	Lookalike audiences built on Ideal Customer (246) cohort
2 — High	Any demographic in Alaska, Pennsylvania, Hawaii	Brand already has high-quality demand there organically — acquisition will find similar-quality customers	Geo-targeted campaigns in top untapped states
3 — High	Footwear and Outerwear buyers with repeat intent	Highest Ideal Customer representation by category	Category-specific retargeting and search campaigns
4 — Medium	Non-subscribed customers showing high frequency	High-Spend Drifter profile — subscription conversion is the lever	Email re-engagement + subscription conversion offer

The Subscription Acquisition Insight

61.0% of Ideal Customers are subscribed vs 26.7% overall. Subscription status is the single variable most predictive of Ideal Customer status. This means the brand's subscription program is not just a revenue feature — it is a **customer quality filter**. Customers who subscribe self-select into higher engagement. The acquisition strategy should therefore prioritise converting any new customer to subscription as quickly as possible, not because of the revenue from the subscription itself, but because subscription correlates strongly with becoming a Champion.

What NOT to Do

- Do not run broad discount-led acquisition campaigns — they will attract Low Priority and Bargain-Hunter profile customers who mirror the customers the sunset plan is designed to phase out
- Do not use Clothing as the primary acquisition category — high volume but lowest Ideal Customer representation (91.4 index). Use Footwear and Outerwear for premium positioning
- Do not target Summer as the primary acquisition season — lowest avg spend (\$58.37) and highest promo rate (43.6%). Fall and Winter yield higher-quality acquisition economics
- Do not build lookalike audiences on the full customer base — the average customer is too diluted by Low Priority and High-Spend Drifter profiles. Build lookalikes on the 246 Ideal Customers only

09 — KPI Monitoring Framework

Every recommendation in this playbook is falsifiable — it either works or it doesn't, and the metrics below are how you know which one is true. This framework is designed to be reviewed at **30, 60, and 90-day intervals** following implementation.

KPI	Current Baseline	90-Day Target	Measurement Method	Alert Threshold
Champion % of base	25.4%	27%+	Segment distribution monthly	If drops below 23%, pause Drifter campaign
Champion promo rate	54.3%	<25%	% Champion orders without promo	If purchase frequency drops >10%, slow rollout
Loyal Low-Spend promo rate	53.7%	<35%	% LLS orders without promo	Monitor repeat purchase rate weekly
High-Spend Drifter subscription rate	10.3%	18%+	Subscription conversions from Drifter cohort	If <5% convert in Month 2, revise offer
Overall promo rate	42.5%	<33%	Promo flag across all transactions	If overall spend drops >5%, review
Avg Champion spend	\$68.94	\$72+	Avg order value for Champion segment	If drops below \$65, investigate
ICP conversion rate	6.4%	8%+	% of base qualifying as Ideal	Lagging indicator — review quarterly
Untapped state customer count	Alaska 72, Hawaii 64	+20% in top 5 states	Customer acquisition by state	Monthly geo acquisition report
Overall subscription rate	26.7%	32%+	Active subscribers / total customers	If Drifter campaign live and rate flat, revise offer
Avg Review Rating	3.75	3.90+	Mean rating across all orders	If drops below 3.5, investigate product/service issue

One Dashboard View to Build First

Before any other dashboard work, build a single weekly view that shows three numbers: (1) Champion promo rate this week vs. last week, (2) Drifter subscription conversion count since campaign launch, (3) overall avg spend vs. prior 4-week average. If all three are trending in the right direction at Week 4, the strategy is working. If any one of them is moving against the expected direction, it warrants investigation before the next phase rolls out.